

Asbury Theological Seminary 2025-26 Workplace Culture Action Plan

The Board of Trustees of Asbury Theological Seminary (ATS) prioritizes the Seminary's workplace culture and has codified its importance through a formal policy in the Board Policy Handbook.

4.6.1 Employee Surveys. In addition to the Institutional Effectiveness & Assessment's annual survey, the CEO is expected to arrange for an annual third-party survey to measure the health of our workplace culture consistent with our values, including feedback on perceptions of and trust in the board and Executive Leadership Team. A comprehensive report on survey results for board discussion should lead to better CEO and board policies and reduce the amount of ad hoc, inappropriate board member engagement with employees other than the CEO.

In the spring of 2025, the Asbury community completed its third cycle of the Best Christian Workplace Employee Engagement Survey. The survey was distributed to all eligible faculty and staff, with 177 employees participating representing an 84% response rate, the highest to date. The results demonstrated notable progress and growing momentum in Asbury's journey toward becoming a thriving workplace.

Dr. Doug Waldo, Senior Consultant with the Best Christian Workplaces Institute, has served as Asbury's lead consultant and primary analyst of the survey results since the initiative began. Dr. Waldo highlighted ***all eight "Flourishing Model" indicators***—Fantastic Teams, Uplifting Growth Sustainable Strategy, Life-Giving Work, Rewarding Compensation, Healthy Communication, Outstanding Talent, Inspirational Leadership, and Engagement Indicators, ***scored higher in 2025***. The Seminary community has much more work to accomplish, but we remain encouraged that the current work is showing *measurable* signs of improvement.

In May of 2025 Dr. Waldo presented the findings to Dr. Gyertson, Interim President and VP and Chief of Staff, ELT, Board of Trustees and Seminary employees. In July an in-depth review of the results was delivered to Dr. Watson, President and the VP and Chief of Staff that included specific recommendations for the administration to *consider* during the 2025-26 academic year.

RECOMMENDATIONS AND ACTION STEPS:

Dr. Waldo suggested reviewing his recommendations and selecting three to prioritize during the 2025-26 academic year. The remaining recommendations should be addressed as soon as possible.

- 1. Ensure that updates are shared promptly among all levels of staff as decisions and events unfold, while continually seeking suggestions for improvement and identify any potential barriers to transparency and timeliness of information shared throughout the organization.***

ACTION STEP(s): In addition to the work of the Leadership Advisory Council, beginning in August, Dr. Watson launched a monthly newsletter distributed to all employees and trustees. The newsletter is designed to keep the community informed by sharing updates from the President and Executive Leadership Team, highlighting institution-wide initiatives, and offering practical information and encouragement from the administration.

To foster connection and build trust among employees, Dr. Watson has committed to hosting informal gatherings where employees can fellowship with the president at least twice a semester during the 2025–26 academic year. These informal gatherings will provide employees an opportunity to get to know the president and strengthen the relationships essential to advancing both employee engagement and the seminary's mission.

In addition, the administration will develop a comprehensive communications plan to maintain transparency and facilitate community feedback as the Seminary implements OME (Optimal Mission Effectiveness) across the institution.

2. ***Evaluate and refine your progress conversations strategy, leveraging a consistent rhythm of 1:1 meeting as well as formal and informal reviews to encourage growth/development. Include a transparent framework for advancement opportunities and career development. Ensure that promotions, raises, and recognition was based on clear, well communicated criteria and provide feedback on how employees can progress.***

ACTION STEP: The Executive Leadership Team (ELT) is implementing a new performance-based compensation plan, scheduled to launch on January 1, 2026. This effort is being supported by a series of training sessions designed for both supervisors and employees. The comprehensive training equips supervisors to provide consistent, *constructive daily coaching*, which in turn informs a robust annual performance review process. This process is anchored in clear employee goals and directly linked to merit-based compensation increases.

Each employee will establish 2 to 5 annual goals in collaboration with their supervisor. These goals will serve as key performance indicators and be used as part of the evaluation process when considering future base salary increases and plans for *professional development*.

3. ***Consider tying wage adjustments to inflation rates to ensure that employees' purchasing power remains stable, and that perceptions regarding fairness and motivation are favorable, even as economic conditions fluctuate. Annually review the compensation strategy to ensure competitive pay and benefits are offered.***

ACTION STEP(s): A cross-functional Compensation and Benefits Project Team led by Bryan Blankenship did extensive work in this area with the result being both a Compensation Philosophy and Compensation Strategy that was reviewed and adopted by the Finance and Operations Committee and Board of Trustees.

In addition, the Finance and Operations Committee (FOC) has included the following in its Charter: “*review of the administration’s periodic compensation studies.*” To support this responsibility, the FOC has incorporated into its regular rhythm of work the completion of a comprehensive compensation study at least every two years.

The FOC will complete the comprehensive compensation study in Fall 2025, with the results informing the implementation of the performance-based compensation program scheduled to launch on January 1, 2026.

Jay Mansur
Vice President and Chief of Staff
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